OPEN LETTER · EYE ON SHOALHAVEN COUNCIL

Three quit Council's Finance and Infrastructure Review Panel before 27 October vote

Sent 17 October 2026 · To Shoalhaven City Council · Response requested by 23 October 2026

OPEN LETTER
To: Clr Patricia White, Mayor, and Mr Andrew Constance, Chief Executive Officer, Shoalhaven City Council
Copied to: All councillors
From: Steve Prothero, Eye on Shoalhaven Council
Date: 17 October 2026
Subject: Finance and Infrastructure Review Panel (CL26.268) — what did it cost in staff time, what did it deliver, and why have all three of its longest-serving community members resigned?

Mayor White and Mr Constance,
On Tuesday, councillors will be asked to receive the resignations of Mr Mark Crowther, Mr Peter Dun and Mr Stuart Coughlan from the Finance and Infrastructure Review Panel, thank them, and start recruiting three replacements. The report (CL26.268) says the resignations were received on 2 October, 26 days before their terms were due to end on 28 October. It rates the risk "minor". It says there are "no direct financial implications". It gives no reason for any of the three leaving.
I think that report asks the wrong question. Before Council spends more staff time refilling the Panel, it should be told what the Panel has cost, what it has produced, and why the people at its centre are walking away. I put those questions to you both, because the Mayor chairs the Panel and the Chief Executive sits on it and runs the staff who service it.
What the public record shows
In my opinion, and I invite you to correct me with facts, the record I can find looks like a poor return on a considerable amount of staff time.
• The Panel was set up in October to December 2024. I can trace a small number of its recommendations adopted by Council in 2025, including the independent review of the Materials Recovery Facility, debt-recovery resources and budget targets. I cannot find a published report on what any of them saved.
• In November 2025 the Panel asked for an investigation into the Flow Power contract, a cost report on the Waste Micro Factory, including a $180,000 recovery, and a land strategy for the Aviation Technology Park. As at August 2026 I can find no report back on the first two.
• On 11 May 2026 an independent member told the Panel the land-sale target was "overly optimistic". Council then voted 7–6 on 28 July to take 20 parcels toward sale. Council now

cites the Panel's call for conservative budgeting to justify the sales.

• On 11 August the Panel declined to receive an incomplete land-sale report and called wages and Materials Recovery Facility data unreliable. Its other recommendation that day was an unfunded $150,000 parking study.

• Panel members discussed resignations at the 19 February 2026 meeting. Two community vacancies were advertised in March and April, and two new members were appointed on 28 July. If the earlier departures were original members, then none of the five original community members will remain after 28 October.

To be fair: the Panel is advisory, it cannot sell land or set budgets, and its best moments were largely the work of its independent members, including Mr Crowther's research on Flow Power and Mr Dun's warning on the land-sale target. That makes their departure more worrying, not less.

The cost

Council has published no figure. On attendance recorded in the Panel's minutes and Council's published salary bands, my own estimate is about $6,000 to $10,000 a meeting in December 2025, rising to $11,500 to $17,000 by September 2026 as nine staff were counted in the room, or roughly $70,000 to $115,000 a year. That is an estimate on stated assumptions, not Shoalhaven payroll data. I would much rather publish yours.

Mr Coughlan

I understand Mr Coughlan supported your campaign for Mayor in 2024. If that is right, it makes the question unavoidable: when a supporter of the chair walks away from the chair's own Panel, along with two colleagues who gave it its sharpest scrutiny, Council should want to know why before it votes to replace them. I make no suggestion about his reasons. I am asking whether anyone has asked.

My questions

Cost

1. How many staff hours, and what dollar cost, has the Panel consumed since its first meeting in December 2024, in agenda preparation, reports, attendance, minutes, follow-up actions and recruitment? Please give it year by year and by classification.

2. What will the proposed recruitment cost in staff time and advertising? CL26.268 says "no direct financial implications"; does that mean the cost has not been calculated?

Delivery

3. What savings, revenue or measurable service improvement can Council attribute to the Panel's work since December 2024? Please list each recommendation, its resolution number, the officer responsible, its status and the dollar result.

4. Has Council received the report the Panel asked for on Flow Power, the Waste Micro Factory $180,000 recovery, and the Aviation Technology Park land strategy? If so, when? If not, why not?

5. Is there an action register for the Panel, and will you publish it?

The resignations

6. Did Mr Crowther, Mr Dun or Mr Coughlan give reasons, in writing or otherwise? Will you ask them whether they are willing to have those reasons reported to Council before Tuesday's vote?
7. Mayor White: have you spoken with the three about their decision, and when did you first learn of it? Mr Constance: were exit conversations held, and by whom?
8. How many community members have resigned from the Panel since December 2024, who were they and when did each leave? Which of the five original members will remain after 28 October?
9. Council discussed resignations at the Panel's 19 February 2026 meeting. What steps were taken then to find out why members were leaving?

The decision on Tuesday

10. Why does the report recommend recruiting three replacements, but not a review of whether the Panel is delivering enough to be worth refilling? Will you move, or support, an amendment deferring recruitment until a report on the Panel's cost, outputs and Terms of Reference comes to Council?
11. The Panel's agendas and minutes are not published as a standing series; they surface only as attachments to other reports. Will you commit to publishing them?

Timing

Please reply in writing by close of business on Friday 23 October 2026, so that all councillors have your answers before they vote on Tuesday 27 October. If any question cannot be answered, please say which and why, so I can report it accurately.

I intend to publish this letter and any reply in full at steveprothero.substack.com and in the Eye on Shoalhaven Council group. If no reply is received by 23 October I will report that plainly.

No adverse finding has been made against any councillor, officer or Panel member, and none is implied. The cost figures are the Eye's estimates and are labelled as such. Where I describe the record, I have relied on Council's agenda CL26.268, Council minutes and Panel documents as reported in earlier Eye articles. I will correct any error promptly and with the same prominence.

Yours sincerely,

Steve Prothero

Eye on Shoalhaven Council

steveprothero.substack.com

Documents relied on: Council agenda, Ordinary Meeting 27 October 2026, item CL26.268 (D26/442461); Finance and Infrastructure Review Panel Terms of Reference (adopted 3 December 2024; amended 24 February 2026; MIN24.493, MIN24.528, MIN26.55); Council resolutions MIN25.110, MIN25.111, MIN25.287, MIN25.288; CL26.154 (appointments, 28 July 2026); Eye on Shoalhaven Council articles of 10 November 2025, 5 December 2025, 18 March 2026, 16 May 2026, 29 July 2026 and 17 September 2026.